

States **MAHARASHTRA**

Mumbai TAMASHA

The Shiv Sena's desperate quest to regain relevance results in a political farce as the targeting of national icons to woo the Marathi *manoos* boomerangs on it

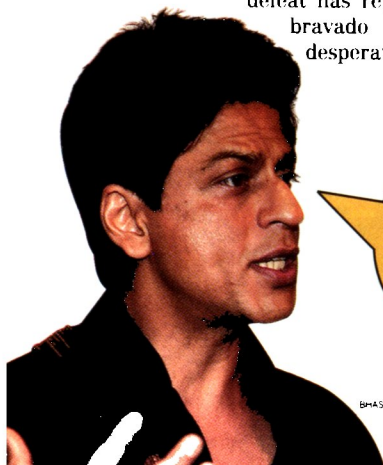
| By Malini Bhupta |

When in doubt, Uddhav Thackeray always pulls out the trump card. Bal Thackeray, from his pack in the hope that it's one ace that will never fail with the Marathi *manoos*. Well, guess what. It seems to have boomeranged badly if public perception is any indication. Ever since he lost the elections, Shiv Sena President Uddhav has struggled to first explain the defeat, then the rise of his cousin Raj Thackeray and, of course, what his party stands for. Not too long ago, when Raj floated the Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS), he had proclaimed that he had "no desire to follow his uncle's brand of politics". But defeat has replaced bravado with desperation.

The ensuing farce in the streets, in television studios and in the Twitterworld is no less dramatic than any Mumbai tamasha.

In less than three months of losing the Maharashtra Assembly elections, the Thackerays have antagonised the younger generation they tried so hard to woo. In the past one month, the Shiv Sena has launched verbal assaults on national icons like cricketer Sachin Tendulkar, actors Shah Rukh Khan and Aamir Khan and Reliance Industries Chairman Mukesh Ambani and poured vitriol on Congress General Secretary Rahul Gandhi. Worse, Uddhav has had to drag the original Shiv Sainik, Bal Thackeray, out of retirement to rescue the Shiv Sena from the mess.

Marooned without an idea or ideology, Uddhav has predictably sought to reincarnate the old party plank of Marathi *manoos*, which was used



SHAH RUKH KHAN

"It was humiliating to see none of the Pakistani players being picked up. The issue could have been handled better."

SAAMNA

"If Shah Rukh wants Pakistani players to play, he should go to Karachi and Islamabad to play with them."

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